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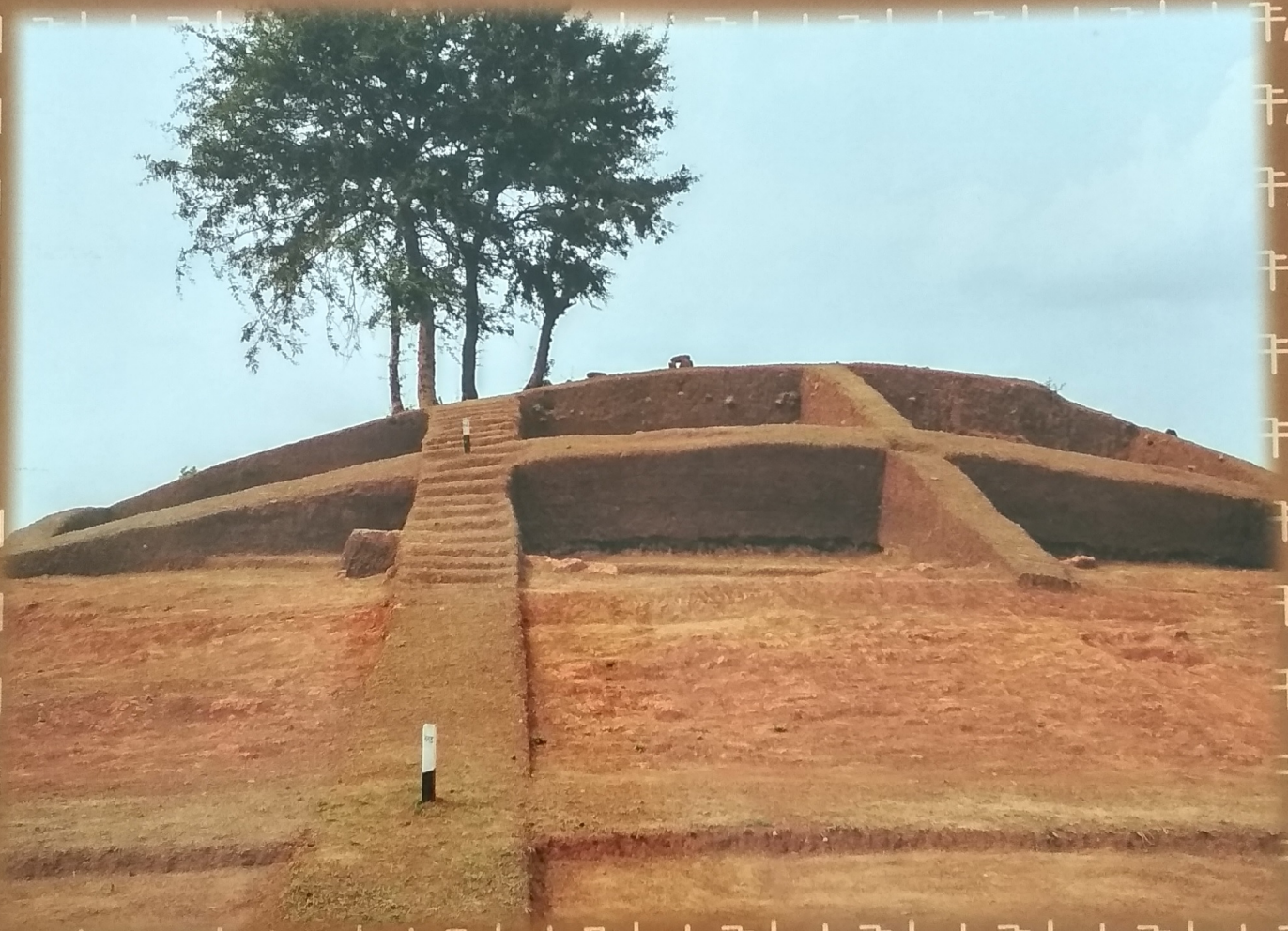

Directorate of Culture and Archaeology
Government of Chhattisgarh
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2020-2-13 11:42

A Fragmentary Lajja Gauri image from Brahmapuri, District-Chandrapur

Dr. Chandrashekhar Gupta* & K.S. Chandak**

Abstract

"*Lajjā Gaurī*, is a goddess associated with abundance and fertility and she has been euphemistically described as *Lajjā* that is modesty"[1]. *Lajjā Gaurī* is a form of *Devī* who is, known by many other names as *Aditi-* in the *Ṛig Veda*, the Primal Mother of the Gods and Goddesses, of the Universe, and of all that lives. Some of Her most famous images are found at *Kudavelli's Sangameshvara* Temple in Andhra Pradesh now in the Alampur Museum; the Nāganātha Temple in Karnataka now in the Badami Museum; and the world-famous Rameshvara rock-cut temple at Ellora. Many of Her images still receive active worship[2]. Early depictions of *Lajjā Gaurī* in Shaktism cults were, found in the Indus Valley seals, though her later depiction dates to the 1st-3rd century, and her worship is prevalent in the Deccan, a region of the Indian subcontinent.

This paper tries to highlight the prevailing cult of *Lajjā Gaurī* in Vidarbha by the way of iconographic evidence through explorations, surface finds and excavations

Keywords : Deccan, *Devī*, *Lajjā Gaurī*, Nagpur District, Nagardhan, Pauni, Paunar, Ramtek, Vidarbha

Introduction[3]

Lajjā Gaurī is a generic noun used to name the iconographic representation of the nude goddess of the fertility cult who offers herself. The noun of '*Gaurī*' appears, in particular, in the chapter, V (verses 8-82) and the chapter XI (verses1-35) of the *Devī Mahātmya* dedicated to the goddess *Durgā*. As *Bhagavatī* or *Devī*, *Gauri* is a respectful synonym to designate *Durgā*, or another goddess. *Devī Mahātmya* a text dedicated to worship of *Devī*, does not record any such name. Probably this may not be the original name of the goddess whose idols today referred as *Lajjā Gaurī* or Shameless goddess. '*Lajjā*' means shame, referring to the erotic iconography of the goddess, nude and the legs apart. This Indian name, which associates *Lajja*-shame, with *Gauri*-goddess *Pārvatī*, and that of a moral judgment on the subject of the sculpture represented. The first artistic representations in India of the goddess are, dated, during the 3rd century CE. However, this date can be, pushed back until the Sunga period. Her attitude is, deemed to represent a woman in labour in stage of expulsion. The image of childbirth is, attributed to the fertility cult as a symbol of regeneration. The goddess in *Lajjā Gaurī* attitude has remained in the dark history of Art from the major archaeological excavations of the mid-19th century to the early of the 20th century; the period being under the influence of the Victorian morality. The *Lajjā Gaurī* attitude is associated with the matriarchal fertility cult dominant in the ancient civilizations from the earliest ages of humanity to the third millennium BCE. The *Lajjā Gaurī* 'Nude goddess legs apart showing her vulva' is a universal representation in the civilizations of the Fertility cult. The flat belly of the goddess demonstrates her intention and her

* Former Professor & Head, Dept. of AIHC&A, RTM Nagpur University
** Contributory Lecturer, Dept of AIHC&A, RTM Nagpur University

2020-2-16 11:42

availability for the act of reproduction. Figured with a swollen belly, it is the image of the childbirth, regeneration of the species. Her artistic representation is cultic; this concept has been there from the beginning of ancient societies.

Discussion

A Fragmentary image (Pl. 1) was, found during surface exploration in the year 1992 by Dr. Chandrashekhar Gupta and K.S. Chandra in agricultural land at Brahmapuri (20.6099°N, 79.8577°E) in Chandrapur District 150 Kms SE of Nagpur, the image made out of black stone is a fragment of a female figure 4 cms in height 2 cms in breadth and 1.5 cms in thickness. The image is, not as intricately carved as the images found elsewhere in Vidarbha suggesting that this might be from early medieval period rather than from ancient period. Considering the image to be, from early medieval period links us to a prevailing trend of *Lajjā Gaurī* worship in Vidarbha region, particularly from the nearby locations like Pauni, Markanda and found fixed on the bastion of *Binabā Dvāra* on *Parakotā* (fortification) of Chandrapur.[4] Another *Lajjā* figure was, found at Bhamragarh, Gadchiroli district by Prof. M.S. Bapgaonkar of PGTD Marathi, Nagpur University details of which are not known.

Photo rendering (Pl. 2) gives us the idea how the full image in its original form might have looked like. Overall look of the image is very simple without any ornamentation, and can be, placed in the type 3 category of *Lajjā Gaurī* images. Only the left half of the figure found in fragmentary condition, it was not easy to recognise the same, but as the broken part was exactly in half, by repeating it the total figure was obtained making it a complete figure of the goddess *Lajjā*. Moreover due to its small size and probably rejected from performing ritual, its condition is very worn out and as stated above the details of the ornamentation are not seen on the figure, still its discovery is significant for giving a clear picture of the cult of this goddess, in this part of Vidarbha region.

The spread of the cult of the mother goddess *Lajjā* is seen in this region in the early medieval period and popularity of this cult is further continues upto late medieval period as evidenced through icon of this goddess from Markanda in Gadchiroli District and Chandrapur.

Findings from Vidarbha

Mahurjhāri, District Nagpur

Hunter published an article reporting *Megalithic* and Early Historic findings from *Mahurjhāri* (Mahurzuri–as spelt by Hunter). Hunter's article primarily reports Early Historic antiquities from *Mahurjhāri,* such as, bricks, seals one with a box-headed script of the *Gupta-Vākātaka* period, in carnelian seal with the letters reading '*apramāda*', an intaglio in early *Vākātaka* character's, a seal in rock-crystal and a '*Nāga*' seal. He also reported finds of a *Lajjā Gaurī* plaque and beads, made of a variety of semi-precious stones at *Mahurjhāri*[5]. Evidence of early historic settlement revealed the evidence of a copper plate, seals, intaglios, beads, bricks and other antiquities of the *Gupta-Vākātaka* period[6]. The site laid bare evidence of a large bead-manufacturing centre in form of finished as well as unfinished beads of semi-precious stones and equipments, which have been, elaborated above. A large amount of full sized burnt bricks and brickbats belong to this period at different levels[7].

Mansar, District Ramtek

During Excavation Period II (Circa 20 to 50 CE), the sculptures mostly Saivite images, particularly belonging to *Tantric* cult, are well, delineated. Sculptures of *Siva -Pārvatī*, *Umā - Maheshwar*, *Ganas*, *Lajjā Gaurī* (Pl. 3)[8], a

2020-2-13

Kinnara, and *Lakshmī* with an attendant and structural fragments were, recovered.

Pauni, District Bhandara

Two plaques depicting the mother goddess *Lajjā* were, noticed by the Department of Ancient Indian History, Culture and Archaeology, Nagpur University, at Pauni in the locality known as, *Tadeshvara* ward. One plaque kept in a small shrine on a platform along with some broken legged querns and worshipped as *Matamai* while the other is in a private shrine[9]. During Excavation[10], surface collection of objects out which an image of *Lajjā Gaurī* and a votive plaque have come from the field. A soap stone image of *Lajjā Gaurī* (13.5 x10.1 cm) characteristically retains the head and her female organ covered with loincloth (Pl. 4)[11]. Her portrayal of *uttānpāda and uttānahasta* postures the deity holds a lotus in her each hand which is only partially visible. The figure, carved in round. Squatting with her legs apart and hands placed on the corresponding knees is largely mutilated. Face is defaced but her hair-do elaborately rendered. On stylistic consideration the sculpture may be, assigned to the early *Vākātaka* Age. A unique plaque depicting an *uttānpada Lajjā Gaurī* with her female organ and head is, replaced with a casket like object, upper surface mutilated. She is, bedecked with a *mekhala* and *nupuras*. To her right is shown a squatting *Nandī* and on her left side of the private organ is seen a female devotee seated in squatting position. It may be, attributed to the *Vākātaka* Period.

Tarapur, District Buldhana

R. C. Agrawal and Amarendra Nath of the South western of the Survey noticed sculptures of *Lajjā Gaurī*, *Siva* and *Pārvaatī*, ascetics, *viragals, nāga-stones,* male heads and an isolated cubical column having figures of females, horse-riders and devotees belonging to the *Yādava* period. Besides, they noticed a temple with the sanctum and *mandapa* built in stone and *shikhara* in brick belonging to the *Yādava* period. Further, they collected sherds of bowls and sprinklers of red polished ware belonging to early historical period.[12]

Recent Findings

Kayar[13], District Yavatmal

The Excavation branch I of Archaeological Survey of India has found remains of a civilization from different periods including the *Sāthavāhana* and *Kshatrapa* dynasties, at Kayar, about 20km from Wani in Yavatmal district. The Survey found the remains during the excavation carried out at this historical multicultural site from January 25 to May 22 2015. One of the typical *Sātavāhana* features found are the remains of a female deity *Lajjā Gaurī* and terracotta ring wells. The palaeography or writing style of the *Kshatrapa* period is an important finding from the site.

Nagardhan, District Nagpur

Dr. Chandrashekhar Gupta of the Department of Ancient Indian History, Culture and Archaeology, Nagpur University, carried out exploration at and around *Nagardhan* in Tehsil Ramtek. He noticed stone images of *Ganapati*, *Lajjā Gaurī* (Pl. 5) and other fragmentary stone sculptures in-situ, datable to the *Vākātaka* period, at *Hamalapuri* and *Nandapuri*, situated at a distance of 2 km E and SE respectively of Nagardhan[14].

Recent Finding at Nagardhan[15]

From last three season's excavation and excavation in second season 2016-17 at *Nagardhan* by Maharashtra State Archaeology Department Nagpur and Deccan College Pune found remnants of a flourishing city in *Vidarbha*,

2020-2-13 11:43

contemporary with the *Guptas*. Throwing light on the ancient town of *Nandivardhana-Nagardhan* was, known as *Nandivardhana* even after the *Rāshtrakutas* ruled 300 years later, enabling earlier scholars to identify it - as the centre of politics and royalty. Religious imagery of *Vishnu, Lajjā Gaurī, Narasimha* were, found on stones and of *Ganapati* in terracotta.

Deccan[16]

The cult of mother-goddess is popular all over the world. In India, representation of this goddess in stone and terracotta are available in many sites in both northern and southern regions. Therefore this must have been one of the mysterious nature-worship cults followed by large a number of people of the middle strata and lower strata. It is in late seventh century that we find sub-shrines for her in the south. To be accommodated in 'shrine' means sanctions from all strata of the society and recognition of the need for worship on large scale. The nude form of the deity appears to be popular in various parts of India and more so in Deccan.

Ter, District Osmanabad[17]

The Department of Archaeology and Museums, Government of Maharashtra, conducted excavations at Ter under the general guidance of A.P. Jamkhedkar and K.D. Kawadkar, assisted by C.S. Sali and G.K. Deshpande. Excavation was, conducted in survey No. 142/2, 250 m away from the northern bank of the river to ascertain the nature of an accidentally exposed brick built tank. In all 12 trenches were laid around the bank. The tank, measures 12-30 x 12-30 x 2-70 m, is, built of burnt bricks with mud mortar, and has two approaches floor. No associated antiquities were, found along with the burial. On the east of the tank, few small oval shaped pits were exposed. The pits were, filled with ash and coal. The walls of the pits were, burnt red. One of the pits contained two bones having cut-marks and a stone. In another three potsherds of red ware were found. From the same trench, mud pallets and broken figure of *Lajjā Gaurī* were, found. Antiquities collected include beads of semi-precious stones, shell bangles, decorated bone, ivory pieces, broken stone sculptures, and ivory comb having depiction of a royal couple attended by female attendants on one side whereas on the other side is the Figure of Lakshmi. The excavation revealed a complex of religious structures of first century AD in which a *tirthakunda,* an apsidal plan, fireplace, offering bowls played an important pan.

Bhokardan, District Jalna

Bhokardan or ancient *Bhogavardhana* stood on the ancient trade route from *Ujjāini* to *Pratishthāna.* The post *Sātavāhana* layers yielded structural remains in form of floor patches, stray alignment of bricks, storage jars and postholes. Two ring wells, one of wedge shaped bricks and other of pottery rings were the most important discoveries in the structures exposed. In this period, terracotta plaques were, found depicting *Lajjā Gaurī* and sculptures of *Siva Linga*[18].

Cult in India[19]

Pre-Historic

The mother-right elements in India are stronger; they worshipped the (Fig) *Pipal* tree as a part of 'primitive phallic cult'. For the *Pipal* tree "…its milk-like sap is associated with fertility cults in Africa, Italy and New Guinea as well as in Assam and Southern India". The prevalence of Mother Goddess worship in the primitive societies of India is, testified among the aboriginal populations of India, where local deities represent the native cults. Hundreds of shrines of these local deities can be, seen in the neighbourhood of every

village. These village deities or '*grama-devata*', with a few exceptions is female. The local people address her as *Mātā* 'The Mother' or *Pedammā* 'The World Mother'. These Goddesses are associated with various diseases and are revered to keep their worshippers away from the curse of these diseases, like *Gangammā*, the Goddess of small-pox, *Marammā*, the Goddess of Cholera, *Kokkalammā*, the Goddess of cough, *Sukhalammā*, the Goddess of measles and *Udalammā*, the Goddess of swollen necks. Goddess *Chāmundi* or the 'Mistress of Death' is widely prevalent in the Canara district and like the Greek Goddess Demeter; she is, referred to as the 'Black One'.

The excavations conducted in 1980 by J. Desmond Clark and G.R. Sharma near Medhauli village in the Sone valley of Madhya Pradesh have revealed the prehistoric worship of the female principle in India. Here, fragments of an 11,000 year old triangular stone were, discovered that were etched with concentric differently colored striations. The stone has been set upon a circular platform of sandstone rubble. The archaeologists discovered that the Kol and Bangā tribes that inhabit the area use similar triangular rocks as '*Shakti* Stones', symbols of their Mother Goddess '*Mai*'. These *Shakti* Stones resemble the triangular 'votive cakes' of the Saraswati Indus Valley sites. The excavations conducted by the Department of Ancient History, Culture and Archaeology, University of Allahabad, in the Belan Valley of Mirzapur district have yielded evidence with regard to the prevalence of Mother Goddess worship in the Upper Palaeolithic period in India. A small female figurine of bone was unearthed from Daiya on the Lohanda of Gravel III content in the Belan valley. A carbon-14 dating of a shell specimen from this deposit is dated 19,715 + 340 B.P., which is consistent with the time span of Upper Palaeolithic in Europe and Western Asia. The figurine is about 8cm high, between 1.5cm and 2.5cm broad and about 1cm i thickness.

"The face is featureless, a triangular formation, the trunk stick-like with a pointed, triangular portion for the legs, and probably the extremity broken. The pendent breasts and the broad loins definitely indicate that this is a female figurine. It bears a remarkable affinity in general with the female figures regarded as Fertility or Mother Goddesses from Western Asia and Eastern and Western Europe. When we find that the C-14 dating places this unique figure in the same general time bracket of 20,000-15,000 B.C. it raises vital questions of culture-contacts and diffusion".

A unique Mother Goddess statue of the Megalithic times in a standing posture has been, found at Adichchānallur. In several respects, this statuette brings us right on the threshold of the historical period. Though unearthed in the Deccan, it is quite dissimilar to its contemporary Mother Goddess images discovered in the South, but resembles the North Indian images and her Western counterparts. Like the Palaeolithic statuette of Willendorf in lower Austria and Gagarino in Russia, it shows a composition of superimposed spheroidal masses for thighs, breasts and a featureless head and barely sketched short arms and stump legs. It also wears an elaborate headdress and necklace with hair locks falling at the back of the head. A three-meter high anthropomorphic stone figure of the Mother Goddess found in Udaiyanattā m village in South Arcot District of Tamil Nadu is a Megalith, surrounded by smaller stones. A similar figure was unearthed from Mettur and two from Andhra Pradesh. These figures resemble the anthropomorphic cult images of Gangetic planes.

2020-21 11:43

A similar figure found in Madhya Pradesh was, identified with the Vedic Goddess *Aditi*. The earliest specimens of terracotta female figures found in Mehrgarh excavation belong to the period that began in 3500 B.C. One of the female figurines is tubular with lower parts missing, a pinched nose and body tied with a rope. Another figure, also in terracotta, has a tubular head with a pinched nose, no arms, pendulous breasts, heavy hips and joined legs with a tapering end in a seated position. These figurines are similar to the Venuses[20] of the Neolithic Age. Specimens of female figurines belonging to the Iron Age found in Nadubelta, South India reveal completely moulded head, eyes, and nose, mouth and ears though the body seems to be hand-modelled. The arms are without any prominent elbow, wrist or fingers. It seems as if the breasts have been, separately made and then affixed to the proper place. The upper body is bare. Another seated figure of the Mother Goddess has, been discovered in Kambhatti Todanad, which holds a child on the right side of her chest. Bare breasts, a symbol, characterize the figure found from Shavaroy Hills of fertility. Another representation of Personified Yoni type female figure has been, found in the Nilgiri Hills. A prehistoric Megalith is still, worshipped as the shrine of the Earth represented by a smooth, oval, red-coated stone. The capstone is about 7ft. long and rings like a bell when struck or when rubbed with another stone in a ritual still practiced. The whole surface has been fashioned as a representation of the Earth Mother who is "the personified abstraction of cosmic life". It is, thus, evident that the Mother Goddess worship prevailed in India in the Pre-Historic times. Although the evidences available are very scanty, yet they are, found from almost a major portion of India, covering Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Central India and some other parts of South India. That the Indians paid reverence to the feminine principle and its unique feature of fertility is, witnessed even today by the respect we have for the Mother. The few available evidences of the Pre-Historic times were, followed by the Proto-Historic period when the Mother Goddess emerges as the supreme deity of the Indus Valley people.

Historic Times

Excavations around Alampur, Nagarjunkonda, in Andhra Pradesh, Siddankotte in Karnataka and Ter, Mahurzuri, Bhokardan in Maharashtra during early 19th century revealed these strange female idols in explicit erotic postures. These female idols were, presented in supine positions, with legs spread wide open, her genitalia and heavy breasts exposed to the viewer's gaze. However, the heads of these idols were missing, instead a lotus flower was, carved in place of the head this mysterious, lotus-headed form of *Devi* is usually, portrayed with legs opened and raised in a manner ambiguously suggesting either childbirth or sexual receptivity. The image is undoubtedly rooted in India's remote prehistory, perhaps originating in the Neolithic Saraswati Indus Valley culture, perhaps earlier. After all, remember that the oldest known sculpture created by a human being Europe's Willendorf Goddess or "Venus," c. 30,000-40,000 BCE - also depicts a nude female deity with a flower for a head.

Early depictions of *Lajjā Gaurī* in Shaktism cults were, found in the Indus Valley seals, though her later depiction dates to the 1st-3rd century, and her worship is prevalent in the Deccan, a region of the Indian subcontinent. Even today, *Lajjā Gaurī* is, actively venerated as a "fertility goddess" in some remote, rural locales. However, during the 6th to 12th centuries CE, her popularly rose, with images proliferating across

central India, both in small terracotta figures for use in home shrines, and in life-size, royally endowed stone sculptures for richly endowed temples. By the 13th century, however, *Lajjā's* cult began a long slide into obscurity; possible factor was the rise of Tantric Goddess worship, which developed subtler, more abstract ways of depicting the primal Yoni, the all-powerful creative force of the Divine Feminine.

Story[21]

No written records exist of *Lajjā Gaurī's* original meaning, but the iconographical evidence is clear. Her frequent juxtaposition with the *Shivalinga* an iconic, phallic form of the Divine Masculine Principle, and her iconographic associations with lion mounts and the god *Ganesh*, suggest beyond a doubt that she was, considered a manifestation of the Supreme *Devī*, specifically *Pārvatī* who is also, called *Gaurī*. Her size always equal to *Shiva's*, and the prominent display of her full breasts suggesting life-giving nurture and sustenance and yoni/vulva, womb; suggesting generative, creative power indicate that she probably served as a Feminine counterpart to the Masculine *linga*. Several myths exist concerning *Lajjā Gaurī*, but scholars consider them inauthentic, late attempts to replace the Goddess's original, forgotten lore. Many of these tales involve a dominant Lord *Shiva* testing his wife's modesty by publicly disrobing her, whereupon her head either falls off or sinks into Her body from shame, thereby proving her purity and providing a *Shiva* -centred explanation of how such a boldly self displaying Goddess got a name like *'Lajjā Gaurī'* literally, 'Modest *Pārvatī*' or 'Ashamed *Pārvatī*'. More useful, clues to her actual meaning may be, found in the oral folktales that still circulate about her in rural India. For example, as noted above, she is often referred, to as *Mātangi*, who is the 'Outcaste Goddess' form of *Pārvatī*, known for ignoring and flaunting society's rules, hierarchies and conventions. Elsewhere, she is, called *Renukā*, an outcaste woman beheaded by a high-caste man. Rather than dying, she grew a lotus in place of her head and became a Goddess. These stories-both involving the deification of an outcaste woman-seem to suggest the irrepressibility of the Feminine Principle, its transcendence of and ultimate superiority over any manmade social systems that would attempt to contain or control the pure force of feminine creative power.

Iconography[22]

Whatever *Lajjā Gaurī* ultimate origins, She is clearly a very auspicious Goddess. Everything about her suggests life, creativity, and abundance. Her images are usually associated with springs, waterfalls and other sources of running water- vivid symbols of life-giving sustenance. Her belly usually protrudes, suggesting fullness or pregnancy; in earlier sculptures, her torso often portrayed as an actual pot, another ancient symbol of wealth and abundance. *Lajjā Gaurī's* head is usually a lotus flower, an extremely powerful, elemental symbol of both material and spiritual well-being. Today's images of the popular Goddess *Lakshmi* patron of wealth and material fulfilment - are also rife with water, pots and lotuses. The often vine-like portrayal of *Lajjā Gaurī's* limbs suggests a further creative association - the life-giving sap of the plant world; she is vegetative as well as human abundance. Her images are virtually always prone, lying at or below floor level in her characteristic uttanapad posture, as though rising from the Earth itself, a manifestation of the primordial *Yoni* from which all life springs. Indeed, her birth/sexual posture unambiguously denote fertility and reproductive power. This is *Devī* as the Creatress, as Mother of the Universe,

2020-21

2020-2-13 11

as the Life-Giving Force of Nature, in a bold, uncompromising display of the Divine Feminine Principle. Her fertility aspect is, emphasized by symbolic representation of the genitals, *Yoni* or the Womb, as blooming Lotus flower denoting blooming youth in some cases and in others through a simple yet detailed depiction of an exposed vulva. Added to the fact that she is sitting in a squatting position *uttānpada* with legs open, as in during childbirth, in some cases, the right foot is, placed on a platform to facilitate full opening. She is, invoked for abundant crops vegetative fertility and good progeny. A blossoming lotus replaces her head and neck, an icon often used in *Tantra*. Further, most fertility goddesses of the Ancient world are similarly, shown headless, while giving prominent focus to the genitals. The arms of the goddess are, bent upwards, each holding a lotus stem, held at the level of the head again depicted by the matured lotus flower. Owing to an absence of verifiable text in Vedic traditions on the iconography she does not seem to hold, any exalted position in Hindu pantheon. Despite her strong presence throughout India, especially in the tribal region of Bastar in Central India and downwards to the South, suggesting that the goddess had a cult of her own, later embraced into the mainstream religion through the myths of *Sati* and *Parvatī*. The goddess is sometimes *Lajjā Gaurī*, interpreted by some as the Innocent Creatrix, the Creator deity or at times simply "Headless Goddess", or *Aditi Uttānpada* by modern archaeologist, academicians and Indologists.

Four Types

1. From Lower portion upto Navel
2. From Lower region upto breast/neck, this is, covered by lotus flower.
3. Raised hands holding buds of flowers above shoulders
4. Complete figure with hands and with intricate ornamentation.

Various Forms[23]

Devī, the Great Mother Goddess of Hinduism, in Her form as *Lajjā Gaurī*[24], is also known as *Aditi*, *Ādyā Shakti*; *Renukā* wife of sage *Jamadagni*, who is worshipped for fertility as *Mātāngi* and *Yallamma* everybody's mother, *Kotari*, *Kotavi* a nude folk goddess, *Kottamahika*, *Kotmai*, and many other names. She is the most ancient Goddess form in the religious complex, today referred to as Hinduism, whose worship is prevalent in villages of Gujarat, Maharashtra where a notable sculpture dating 150 - 300 CE was, found at *Āmarāvāti* (now kept at State Museum, Chennai. Tribal areas of Central India, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, where the town of *Bādāmi*, known for the *Bādāmi* Cave Temples, has a sculpture of the deity preserved at the local Archaeological Museum, originally found in *Nāganātha* Temple, *Nāganāthakolla* in *Bijapur* District. An extant temple dedicated to the goddess in *Bādāmi Chālukyā* Architecture, within the town precincts dating to *Chālukyā* Empire which flourished around 6th century AD.

Association with Other Deities

Associated with *Shiva, Nandi, Ganesh, Mahishasurmardini*

Identification

Lajjā Gaurī has been, called differently by various writers. First among the writers is Stella Kramrisch, who identified the goddess as *'Aditi Uttānpadā'*. She says: "*Aditi* is fearless, parturient, birth giving. No image of her could be made based on her evocation in the texts". H.D. Sankalia, called her a 'Shameless Woman', and opined that this cult was, imported by Romans sometime during the opening centuries of the Christian era. Carol Radcliffe also identifies these

images as the representations of *Aditi*, which were, worshipped by barren women for procuring an off spring. Recently, R.C. Dhere has based his arguments of the name *Lajjā Gaurī*, on the local *Māhātmye*, the *Mahākuta Māhātyme,* which has a legend referring to '*Lajjā Gaurī*'. M.K. Dhavalikar identifies her as *Shākambharī*, the goddess of Vegetative Fertility, based on *Skanda-purāṇa*[25] and with *Pālghāt,* a goddess worshipped by newlywed *Wārli* couples of coastal Maharashtra region.

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19. http://shodhganga.inflibnet.ac.in/bitstream/10603/20264
20. The Venuses of Neolithic Period are also headless, have pendulous breasts, prominent navel, slender waist and highly developed buttocks. Most of them are in squat posture, suggestive of pregnancy or childbirth.
21. https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Lajja_Gauri&oldid=802676159
22. https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Lajja_Gauri&oldid=802676159
23. https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Lajja_Gauri&oldid=802676159
24. Another interpretation as suggested by Dr. Ramachandra C. Dhere in his book entitled, *Lajjā Gaurī* is that *Lanja/Lanjika* means 'naked', reminds us of the geographical area in Konkan (Maharashtra), called *Lanja*.
25. http://shodhganga.inflibnet.ac.in/bitstream/10603/105333

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2020-2-13

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